Royal Devon and Exeter NHS
NHS Foundation Trust

Clinical Guideline for:
Difficult airway trolley

SUMMARY

Difficult airway equipment is kept in the bottom draw the intubation trolleys. There is one trolley on the old unit behind the nurses' station and an identical trolley in the new part of the ICU outside bed 13. Staff should know the location and contents of the trolleys, and be familiar with equipment they expect to use.

KEY POINTS

The following equipment is available on the difficult airway trolley:

- To facilitate laryngoscopy:
  - Airtrac (blue) – fits ETTs 7.0-8.5
  - McCoy laryngoscope blade
  - The C-mac is kept by the nurses' station in the new part of the ICU with a standard Mac 3 blade. The 'D' blade is kept with the theatres C-mac, found outside theatre 9 when not in use. A paediatric blade is kept on top of the paediatric airway trolley in room 8.
- To facilitate intubation:
  - Portex gum elastic bougie
  - Cook airway exchange catheter
- Alternative airway devices:
  - Size 4 i-gel
  - Size 3 & 4 re-usable laryngeal masks
  - Size 4 & 5 intubating laryngeal masks (old-unit trolley only)
- Emergency tracheostomy devices:
  - Melker emergency cricothyroidotomy set
  - Scalpel and 6.0mm ETT
- A laminated copy of the Difficult Airway Society 2015 difficult intubation guidelines is included to guide management

(see notes, below)

Notes:

- All clinicians involved in airway management on the ICU should familiarise themselves with the above equipment.
- The most important piece of difficult airway equipment is a clinician experienced in airway management.
- If an airway is expected to be difficult senior advice and assistance should be sought. Advanced airway management equipment is no substitute for prior planning and expert airway skills.
- In the event of an unanticipated difficult airway the priority is always to maintain oxygenation above all else until expert assistance arrives, not to achieve intubation at all costs.
- There is a 'difficult airway bag' in theatre 9 which can be taken to the wards/radiology/cath lab. There is also a portable C-mac handle which will attach to a C-mac blade to make a handheld videolarygoscope. You must remember to take a C-mac blade as well as the handle.

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